

Analyzing data on the level of cognitive processes - ESCoP 2025

Gidon T. Frischkorn, Ruhi Bhanap, and Isabel Courage

Exercise 2: Hierarchical Models & Signal Detection Theory

A - Fit Bayesian GLMs to the aggregated data

1. Load the aggregated data of Williams et al. (2022) `exercise2_Williams2022_exp2_aggregated.txt`.

This data set contains aggregated performance indices from a Change Detection Task with Set Size 8 and a between subject manipulation `isAdaptive`. The manipulation entailed a prompt pushing participants to respond equally often with `same` and `different` to achieve a less biased response pattern.

2. Fit Bayesian GLMs with either proportion correct, Cowan's K and dprime as the dependent variable

Use the `brm` function to specify that the DV should vary as a function of the `isAdaptive` between subject manipulation. Set appropriate priors for the `b` coefficients for the respective models. Use the `default_prior` function to get information which priors are set as a default by `brms`. Set the `sample_prior` option to `TRUE` when fitting the model.

3. Quantify the strength of evidence for or against an effect of the manipulation

The `hypothesis` function allows to specify to-be-tested hypothesis for any GLM fitted with `brms`. For this you need to pass the `brmfit` object and a vector of character strings specifying the hypothesis you want to test.

B - Fit Bayesian-hierarchical SDT model to the data

1. Load the non-aggregated data of Williams et al. (2022): `exercise2_Williams2022_exp2.txt`

This data contains more detailed data on the number of hits and false alarms for trials with targets and foils as test stimuli.

2. Specify the non-linear formula to fit an SDT model with this data

Use the `brmsformula` function to specify the non-linear formula implementing an SDT model in a GLM. Predict both `dprime` and the `criterion` by the `isAdaptive` manipulation.

3. Fit the SDT model to the data

Pass the `brmsformula` to the `brm` function and select to fit a binomial model with a probit link function. Again consider specifying adequate priors for the parameters. And use the `hypothesis` function to test on which parameters of the SDT model the `isAdaptive` manipulation has an effect.